



# Reading a Load Board Posting

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 5 of 18 · Finding & Judging the Load · about a 18-minute read

A new dispatcher opens the load board for the first time and nearly closes it again. It's a wall — hundreds of rows, codes, abbreviations, numbers stacked on numbers. Then one jumps out: "\$2,800 — Atlanta!" He gets excited and calls on it.

Three things he'd have known in five seconds if he could read the posting: it's a **flatbed** load, and his driver runs a dry van — he can't haul it. It's **1,400 miles**, so that big-looking number is really only about two dollars a mile — nothing special. And the broker on it has a history of paying slow. He just spent his energy — and a little of his credibility — on a load that was never his to take.

*The board hands you everything you need to make that call correctly — lane, equipment, weight, rate, miles, dates, who's offering it, even how they pay. It's all right there in the posting.*

## WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Look at any load posting and read it like a pro: know what every field means, and run a quick judgment — *can my truck take it, does the rate beat what it costs me to run, and is the deadhead reasonable* — so you know in seconds whether it's worth picking up the phone. This is the filter that runs your whole day at the board.

## 1 The Board, and Finding Your Loads in It

The **load board** is the online marketplace where brokers post the freight they need moved and you shop for loads that fit your truck. The first thing you'll notice when you sit in front of it: there's way too much to read all of it. The skill isn't reading everything — it's filtering down to what matters and reading *those* fast.

So you filter. You tell the board two things: where your truck is, and what kind of truck it is. For Summit, that's "near Atlanta" and "dry van." You set an origin and a radius — say, loads picking up within a hundred miles of where Marcus is sitting — and your equipment type, and the board narrows that wall down to the loads you could actually run. From there, it's posting by posting.

## 2 The Anatomy of a Posting

Almost every posting shows the same handful of fields. Here's our furniture load, the way it'd look on the board:

| ATLANTA, GA → DALLAS, TX                  |                                         |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| EQUIPMENT<br><b>V — dry van</b>           | WEIGHT<br><b>38,000 lbs</b>             |
| TRIP<br><b>1,000 mi</b>                   | RATE<br><b>\$3,000 (\$3.00/mi)</b>      |
| PICKUP<br><b>Tue 8:00 AM</b>              | DELIVERY<br><b>Thu</b>                  |
| COMMODITY<br><b>Furniture</b>             | LOAD TYPE<br><b>Full load (FTL)</b>     |
| BROKER<br><b>Smith Logistics</b>          | CONTACT<br><b>Greg · (xxx) xxx-xxxx</b> |
| CREDIT SCORE<br><b>92 · pays ~25 days</b> | REFERENCE #<br><b>SL-4471</b>           |
| POSTED<br><b>2 hrs ago</b>                | NOTES<br><b>none</b>                    |

Read it field by field — each one is telling you something:

**The lane** — origin and destination. A **lane** is just one place to another, and it's the first thing you check: does it go where you want your truck to go?

**Equipment and weight** — this is your equipment gate. V means dry van, which matches Marcus; 38,000 is well under the limit. If the code were R or F, or the weight pushing past 45,000, you'd slow down or skip.

**Trip miles and rate** — together these are the whole money question (the next two sections). The board often does the division for you — \$3.00 a mile — but never trust someone else's math; check it yourself.

**Pickup and delivery** — the timing. *Whether* it's even possible we answer next lesson; for now just check the dates work with where your truck is and when it's free.

**Commodity and load type** — what's in the trailer (usually routine, but it flags special handling). "Full load," or FTL, means the whole trailer is yours — the only kind of freight we deal with.

**Broker and contact** — who you'd call. This is where your phone fundamentals kick in.

**Credit and days-to-pay** — your first quick read on whether the broker actually pays. A healthy score like 92 with reasonable timing is a green light; a low score or slow pay is a yellow flag worth a *closer look*. Glancing here is triage — really vetting a broker is its own lesson shortly.

**Reference number, age, and notes** — the ref number identifies this exact load; "posted 2 hours ago" tells you how fresh it is; and **notes** is where special requirements hide (tarps, hazmat, a team requirement). Always read the notes.

## 3 Judging the Rate: RPM vs CPM

The most important judgment you'll make on every load: is the rate any good? And "good" doesn't mean "big" — it means *profitable for your truck*. Two numbers tell you that.

**RPM** — rate per mile. Take the rate, divide by the loaded miles. Our load: \$3,000 over 1,000 miles is **\$3.00 a mile**. That boils any load's pay down to a number you can compare. **CPM** — your cost per mile — is what it actually costs *you* to put the truck down the road for one mile (fuel, truck payment, insurance, maintenance, tolls, and the driver), divided by the miles you ran. For Summit, say that's about **\$1.85 a mile**. That's your break-even — your cost line.

RPM (pay) **\$3.00 / mi**

CPM (cost) **\$1.85 / mi**

The gap — **\$1.15 / mi** — is your margin. A load makes money only when RPM is above CPM; below it, you lose money on every mile.

Here's the whole game in one sentence: **a load makes money when its RPM is higher than your CPM, and the gap is your margin**. Our furniture load pays \$3.00 against a \$1.85 cost — a dollar fifteen a mile, across a thousand miles. Profitable. Flip it: a load paying \$1.50 against a \$1.85 cost *loses* thirty-five cents every mile — not a deal at any size, a slow leak. You pass, or you get on the phone and push the rate up.

## 4 Why the Rate Moves with the Miles

Here's what trips up every beginner: a high RPM is not the same as a good day. Watch what happens to rate per mile as loads get longer — a short run pays a *high* number per mile; a long run pays a *low* one. And the surprise is that **both can be perfectly fine**. Roughly, on dry van, the bands look like this:

Under 200 mi **~\$5-9 / mi**

200-400 mi **~\$3.50-4.50 / mi**

400-700 mi **~\$3.00-3.75 / mi**

700-1,100 mi **~\$3.00-3.25 / mi**

1,100 mi + **~\$3.00 / mi (floor)**

See the slope — the shorter the haul, the higher the rate per mile. That's RPM running **inverse** to distance. It looks backwards until you see *why*.

**On a short run, the constraint isn't distance — it's time.** Loading the trailer, the paperwork, the appointment you have to hit, unloading at the other end — all of that costs you the *same* whether the trip is 150 miles or 700. A short load burns a big chunk of your day on everything *except* driving, so the only way short miles are worth running is if they pay a high rate per mile to make up for the day they eat. Long hauls flip it: the truck is just rolling, mile after mile, so the per-mile rate can be low and still fill the day with paid miles.

Which brings in a clock you haven't met yet: the **dock clock**. Every pickup and delivery has an **appointment window** — a time the facility will actually load or unload you. Those windows, plus how long a dock takes, cap how many loads you can physically complete in a day. That's a *different* limit from the driving-hours law you'll meet next lesson — your driver might have plenty of legal hours left, but if the docks won't see him, the hours don't help. Two 250-mile loads is easy on driving hours and usually *impossible* on dock windows. So before you ever count on running two loads in a day, you check the appointment times.

Now the model you actually run your day by — three lines, named clearly:

- 1 **Break-even — your cost line.** About **\$1.85 a mile** for Summit. The wall below which a load loses money. Never the goal — just the floor under the floor.
- 2 **Your floor — \$3.00 a mile** on a normal single dry-van haul. We do *not* run dry van below three dollars a mile. It sits well above break-even; below it, you negotiate up or you pass.
- 3 **Your daily goal — about \$1,500 a day.** This is the number you actually manage to. You judge the *day*, not just the load.

Those three change the question you ask. It's never just "is *this* load good?" — it's "**does my day hit \$1,500?**" That's the stacking rule. You *can* run a cheaper short load — say it only pays about **\$750** — but only on one condition: it has to be short enough that you can fit a *second* load the same day and clear your \$1,500 goal, *and* the pickup and delivery windows have to actually allow both to be completed. Check that against the dock clock first. If you can only physically fit *one* load that day, that load has to carry the whole \$1,500 by itself — and a \$750 load can't. So what you're really maximizing isn't the rate of any single load — it's **dollars per day**, and the *blended* rate per mile across the loads you stack together.

## 5 The Deadhead Bite: Your Real Rate

One more number quietly changes the math, and beginners miss it: **deadhead** — the empty miles your truck drives just to get to the pickup. Those miles cost fuel and time and earn nothing, so they eat into the real rate.

$$\text{\$3,000} \div \text{1,150 mi (1,000 loaded + 150 deadhead)} = \sim\text{\$2.61 / mi real rate}$$

Still above the \$1.85 cost — but the empty miles quietly knocked \$0.39 off the \$3.00 posted rate, dropping it below your \$3.00 floor.

That's the lesson: a load with a beautiful loaded RPM and a long deadhead can look like a winner and actually be a loser once you count the empty miles. So when you judge a rate, judge it against where your truck actually *is*.

## 6 Spot vs. Contract — and "Posted" Isn't "Final"

Most loads on the board are at a **spot rate** — a one-off, today's-market price for this single load, moving daily (sometimes hour to hour) with how many loads and trucks are out there. The contrast is a **contract rate** — a price agreed in advance over time or volume; steadier and usually a little lower, but set up as ongoing business, not grabbed off the board. So on the board, assume you're looking at spot.

And this: the number on the posting is a *starting point*, not a final price. Plenty of postings even say "call for rate" and show no number at all. Either way, the rate is something you'll often move — but *how* you negotiate is its own lesson. For now, just don't treat the posted number as locked.

## 7 Putting It Together: The Triage

Here's how it all comes together into one fast pass — most of it you can do in your head in a few seconds:

- 1 **Equipment & weight** — can my truck even take it? (*If no, stop here.*)
- 2 **Rate** — is the RPM above break-even with the deadhead counted — *and* at or above your \$3/mi floor, with the day on track to \$1,500? (*If below, it's a pass or a negotiation.*)
- 3 **Deadhead** — is repositioning to the pickup reasonable?
- 4 **Timing** — do the dates look plausible for where my truck is? (*Whether it's truly doable, we confirm next lesson.*)
- 5 **Broker** — anything obviously off about who's posting it? (*Real vetting comes shortly.*)

Pass all five and you've got a candidate worth a call. The board lets you *triage* fast and weed out the no's, so you only spend real time — the deep feasibility check, the vetting, the phone call — on loads that already look right. That's how a good dispatcher gets through hundreds of postings and still books the good ones.

# Walkthrough — Three Postings, Triageed

Marcus has a dry van near Atlanta; Summit's CPM is about \$1.85/mi, and the dry-van floor is \$3.00/mi.

### Load A • Atlanta → Dallas

V • 38,000 lbs • 1,000 mi • \$3,000 • pickup tomorrow AM  
Equipment? V = van ✓ RPM? \$3.00 clears break-even, at the \$3 floor ✓ Deadhead ~150 mi → ~\$2.61/mi, above cost ✓ Timing plausible ✓ →  
**CALL** — a long haul right at your floor, a utilization load (our furniture load).

### Load B • Atlanta → Miami

V • 30,000 lbs • 660 mi • \$800 • pickup today  
Equipment? V = van ✓ RPM?  $\$800 \div 660 = \$1.21/\text{mi}$  X (below the \$1.85 break-even AND far under the \$3 floor) → **SKIP**, or call only to push the rate up. As posted, it loses money.

### Load C • Atlanta → Dallas

R • produce • 42,000 lbs • 1,000 mi • \$2,600 • pickup tomorrow  
Equipment? R = reefer, needs cooling — Marcus's dry van can't X → **SKIP**. The \$2,600 doesn't matter; the truck can't haul it.

Three postings, a few seconds each, one clear winner. Load A reads right on every count — it clears break-even, sits right at the \$3 floor loaded, and even with the deadhead pays about \$2.61 all-in. Load B looks fine until you do the RPM — \$1.21 against a \$1.85 cost is a money-loser, and nowhere near the \$3 floor. Load C pays the best of the three and is useless to Marcus because it needs a reefer. The equipment gate and the rate math together tell you, fast, where to spend your time.

## Module 5 Glossary — your quick reference

The board-reading language, in one place.

### Finding & Judging Loads

|                            |                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Load board</b>          | The online marketplace where brokers post freight and carriers find loads that fit their truck.  |
| <b>Lane</b>                | One origin-to-destination route (e.g., Atlanta→Dallas) — the first thing you check on a posting. |
| <b>RPM (rate per mile)</b> | The load's rate divided by its loaded miles — a comparable measure of what a load pays.          |
| <b>CPM (cost per mile)</b> | What it costs you to run the truck one mile (all costs ÷ miles) — your profitability floor.      |
| <b>Margin</b>              | The gap between RPM and CPM — what's left after costs. A load earns only when RPM is above CPM.  |
| <b>Deadhead</b>            | Empty miles driven to reach the pickup — they earn nothing and lower your real, all-in rate.     |
| <b>Spot rate</b>           | A one-off, daily-moving market price for a single load — most of what's on the board.            |
| <b>Contract rate</b>       | A steadier, pre-agreed price over time or volume — ongoing business, not grabbed off the board.  |

## Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. What does RPM mean, and how do you calculate it?
2. What is CPM, and why do you compare every load's RPM to it?
3. A load pays \$1,500 for 1,000 miles. Summit's CPM is \$1.85. Is it worth taking as posted?
4. A load shows a great \$2.10 loaded RPM, but the pickup is 300 deadhead miles away on a 700-mile load. Why should that change your read?
5. What's the difference between a spot rate and a contract rate, and which do you see on the board?
6. A 180-mile load pays \$6.00/mi and a 1,000-mile load pays \$3.00/mi. Why can both be good loads — and what number do you actually judge your day by? When does it make sense to take a cheaper ~\$750 short load?

### ANSWERS

1. Rate per mile — the load's rate divided by its loaded miles ( $\$3,000 \div 1,000 \text{ mi} = \$3.00 \text{ RPM}$ ).
2. Cost per mile — what it costs you to run the truck one mile; it's your break-even, your cost line (about \$1.85 for Summit). A load only makes money if its RPM is above your CPM; below it, you lose money on every mile.
3. No — RPM is \$1.50, below the \$1.85 cost, so you'd lose ~\$0.35/mile. Pass, or call only to negotiate the rate up.
4. The empty miles count against the real rate. The truck runs 1,000 miles total for the pay, so the effective rate is  $\text{rate} \div (700+300)$  — meaningfully lower than \$2.10. Judge the rate against where the truck actually is.
5. Spot = a one-off, daily-moving market price for a single load; contract = a steadier pre-agreed rate over time/volume. The board is mostly spot.
6. Rate per mile runs inverse to distance — short hauls pay a high \$/mi because time, not distance, is the constraint (loading, appointments, and unloading cost the same whether it's 150 or 700 miles), while long hauls pay a low \$/mi but fill the day with paid miles. You judge the *day*, not the load: the real yardstick is dollars per day (~\$1,500), above your break-even (~\$1.85) and your \$3/mi floor. A cheap ~\$750 short load is only worth it if it's short enough to fit a second load the same day to clear \$1,500 — and only if the pickup/delivery appointment windows (the dock clock, which caps loads-per-day separately from driving hours) actually allow both to be completed. If only one load fits that day, it has to carry the whole goal itself.

### WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 6: IS THIS LOAD EVEN DOABLE?

Now you can spot a load worth chasing — right truck, rate that beats your cost, deadhead you can live with. But "worth chasing" isn't the same as "doable." Before you ever call and commit to that pickup and delivery, you have to be sure the truck can *legally and physically* make it on time — which comes down to the driver's hours and the math of the road.

### YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches board-reading with a generic ~\$1.85 break-even, a \$3.00/mi floor, and a ~\$1,500/day goal as stand-ins. Your own operation adds its specifics — the exact load board(s) and login, how the board is set up (saved searches, default radius, preferred lanes), its *real* CPM and target/minimum RPM, any rate floors, and where you record loads you're working. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*